

# Speed of Tape (Instant)

Indicators & Analysis / Volume & Delta | intermediate | 4 min read | DeepCharts Help Center | August 24, 2026

Speed of Tape (Instant) measures instantaneous trade execution speed — how much is trading right now within a short rolling time window. Bar height shows how fast the tape is running; bar color shows whether buying or selling pressure dominates the flow being measured.

Where the standard Speed of Tape indicator plots pace as a historical series, the Instant variant keeps you focused on the last few readings, making it a real-time urgency gauge for active trading.

The streaming tape below is the raw flow this indicator distills — watch the buy/sell/delta counters shift as prints roll in, and filter by All/Ask/Bid to isolate one side.

[WIDGET: tape-lab]

## What it is

The indicator analyzes volume flow over a configurable window (**Number of seconds**, default **10**) and draws the result as colored bars: green/teal bars mark positive-delta periods where buying pressure dominates, red/pink bars mark negative-delta periods where selling pressure dominates, and bar height reflects trading velocity intensity. By default only the most recent readings are shown (**Bars to show**, default **3**), keeping the display anchored to the present.

[ SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER ] Chart with Speed of Tape (Instant) active — the three most recent tape-speed bars visible, tallest bar in the buy color during a fast push up, price candles moving in the background

dc-en-speed-of-tape-instant-01.png

## When to use it

- You confirm momentum in real time: sudden tape-speed spikes in the direction of your trade validate the entry.
- You watch for exhaustion: bars progressively shortening while price extends warns the move is running out of participation.
- You identify acceleration phases: progressively taller bars flag institutional-scale urgency building.
- You recognize consolidation: persistently low velocity tells you to expect chop rather than follow-through.

## Quick start

1. Open the **Indicator List** on your chart and add **Speed of Tape (Instant)**.
2. Open the indicator's **Settings**.
3. Keep **Input data** on **Volume** (the default) to weight speed by traded size (see Different Types of Input Data for Indicators).
4. Leave **Number of seconds** at the default **10** and **Display value** on **Total** — this aggregates all trading activity within each 10-second window.
5. Keep **Bars to show** at the default **3**; increase it only if you want more recent history in view.

[ SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER ] Speed of Tape (Instant) settings dialog — Plot Settings with Bars to show = 3 and Scale min value = 0, Data Settings and Mode Settings sections visible with Number of seconds = 10

dc-en-speed-of-tape-instant-02.png

## How to read it

- **Tall bar, buy color** — heavy activity dominated by buying pressure; momentum confirmation for longs.

- **Tall bar, sell color** — the same urgency on the sell side.
- **Bars shrinking across readings** — an exhaustion signal: each window is quieter than the last even if price is still drifting.
- **Bars growing across readings** — an acceleration phase; breakouts starting on rising tape speed carry more weight.
- **Uniformly short bars** — low velocity, typical of consolidation; signals from other tools fire less reliably here.

Remember the color encodes delta dominance within the measured window, not the direction of the current candle — a red speed bar can print while price ticks up if sellers dominate the executed flow.

## Settings reference

### Plot Settings

| Setting                | What it does                                                                                  |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Bars to show</b>    | How many historical bars of Speed of Tape data are displayed on the chart. Default <b>3</b> . |
| <b>Scale min value</b> | Establishes the baseline for the visual representation of tape speed. Default <b>0</b> .      |

### General (Candle Settings)

| Setting                                                        | What it does                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Line width</b>                                              | Bar thickness for visibility. Default <b>1</b> .                  |
| <b>Plot reversed</b>                                           | Reverses the vertical orientation of the bars when enabled.       |
| <b>Delta Positive</b>                                          | Color for positive-delta (buy-dominant) bars. Default green/teal. |
| <b>Delta Negative</b>                                          | Color for bars representing negative-delta periods.               |
| <b>Delta Positive (Secondary) / Delta Negative (Secondary)</b> | Additional color options for each side.                           |

### Data Settings

| Setting           | What it does                                                                                                      |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Input data</b> | Data source: <b>Volume</b> (default) or <b>Order</b> flow data. See Different Types of Input Data for Indicators. |
| <b>Filter min</b> | Excludes low-activity periods from the calculation.                                                               |
| <b>Filter max</b> | Caps extremely high activity periods. Default <b>0</b> (no limit).                                                |

### Mode Settings

| Setting                  | What it does                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Display value</b>     | How activity in the window is summarized. Default <b>Total</b> — aggregates all trading activity within the specified time window. |
| <b>Number of seconds</b> | The time window in seconds over which tape speed is calculated. Default <b>10</b> .                                                |

## Tips and common mistakes

- **Ten seconds is a sensible default — but not sacred.** Scalpers on very fast symbols may prefer a shorter window; slower instruments read better with a longer one. Change one thing at a time.

- **Do not treat color as a trade signal.** The delta coloring shows who dominated the measured flow; direction still needs price and structure to confirm.
- **Keep Bars to show small.** The indicator's value is its immediacy — turning it into a long history duplicates what Speed of Tape already does better.
- **Use Filter min to mute noise on thin markets,** where a handful of small trades can otherwise register as meaningless "speed."

## Related articles

- [Speed of Tape](#)
- [Delta Bar](#)
- [Big Trades](#)
- [Orderflow 101: Bid, Ask, Aggressor and Delta](#)
- [Different Types of Input Data for Indicators](#)
- [How to Change the Layout of Indicators](#)